



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS
INSIDER'S TOP TIPS
FOR APPLYING TO
STANFORD GSB

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ABOUT THE SCHOOL

"The majority of people who go to GSB do extraordinary things in ordinary jobs." Stanford's MBA Program is the most selective in the world. It has maintained the highest ratio of applicants to available seats of any business school in the U.S. for the last decade. It has also had the lowest acceptance rates of any major business school in the world. Accepting only 6% of those who apply for admission, yield is over 86%. No school is more choosy than Stanford.

The Stanford MBA class size is less than half the size of Harvard. And with Silicon Valley in its back yard, a growing number of tech and engineering applicants are choosing the GSB over their East coast rival. The small class size lends itself to an intimate and close-knit community environment and pretty much guarantees that almost every student knows each other. Its motto is "Change Lives, Change Organizations, Change the World."

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

As you might expect from one of the world's top business schools, Stanford's MBA program is known for its strengths across many areas, in particular entrepreneurship, innovation, finance, technology, general management and social enterprise.

INCOMING CLASS

Number of Applicants: 7,797 MBA Class Size: 419
Admissions Selectivity: 6.0% Yield: 85%
Total Tuition: \$141,180

POST-MBA CAREERS

Sector: Financial Services 31%; Technology 33%; Entrepreneurs 16%; Consulting 18%;
Healthcare 6%
Avg. Base Salary: \$144,455 Employment in 3 months: 92%

MBA RANKINGS

	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018
BusinessWeek	4	4	4	7	2	2	1
Financial Times	1	2	2	4	5	2	1
Forbes	-	1	-	1	2	-	-
The Economist	8	7	7	11	5	-	5
US News	1	1	1	1	2	4	4

ADMISSIONS

Avg. Work Exp.: 4 yrs Avg. GMAT: 732 Avg. GPA: 3.74
Int'l Students: 42% Female Students: 41%

Deadlines for 2018-2019:
Round 1 - Sep 12, '19
Round 2 - Jan 9, '20
Round 3- Apr 8, '20

Sources: Stanford GSB, BusinessWeek, Financial Times, US News, MBA50



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ESSAYS 2019-2020:

Cites Stanford GSB on its website: In each essay, we want to hear your genuine voice. Think carefully about your values, passions, aims, and dreams prior to writing them.

1. What matters most to you, and why?

For this essay, we would like you to:

- Do some deep self-examination, so you can genuinely illustrate who you are and how you came to be the person you are.
- Share the insights, experiences, and lessons that shaped your perspectives, rather than focusing merely on what you've done or accomplished.
- Write from the heart, and illustrate how a person, situation, or event has influenced you.
- Focus on the "why" rather than the "what."

750 Words (suggested)

2. Why Stanford? Enlighten us on how earning your MBA at Stanford will enable you to realize your ambitions.

- Explain your decision to pursue graduate education in management.
- Explain the distinctive opportunities you will pursue at Stanford.

400 words (suggested)

Length: Your answers for both essay questions combined may not exceed 1,150 words (1,200 words if you are applying to both the MBA and MSx programs). Each of you has your own story to tell, so please allocate these words between your essays in the way that is most effective for you. Above is a suggested word count, based on what we typically see.

The new optional prompt: Think about times you created a positive impact, whether in professional, extra-curricular, academic, or other settings. What was your impact? What made it significant to you or others? You are welcome to share up to three examples. (Up to 1500 characters, approximately 250 words each)

Formatting:

- Double-spaced
- Write the question you are answering at the beginning of each essay (does not count toward the word limit)
- Number all pages
- Upload one document that includes all essays
- Be sure to save a copy of your essays and preview the uploaded document to ensure that the formatting is preserved.



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By Matt Symonds

Matt Symonds is the author of the international bestseller "Getting the MBA Admissions Edge," sponsored by Goldman Sachs, McKinsey & Co., BCG, and Bain & Co. As the founder of the World MBA Tour in 1995, he has an extensive business school network, regularly interviewing deans, faculty and admissions directors for the media, and his industry knowledge makes him a regular guest expert on TV, in the press, and at conferences. He covers business education for BusinessWeek, The Economist, Forbes, America Economia, Times of India and many other global publications.

Tip #1 - Defining change

There are not many institutions in the world that can get away with the tagline "Change lives. Change organizations. Change the world." But Stanford might be one of them. So when it comes to defining your career goals, you should bear in mind that the admissions office is seeking individuals who are looking to have real impact, whether professionally or in society. The selectivity of the business school means that they can look beyond students whose goal is to secure a place in a strategy consulting firm or investment bank, and identify those applicants who are driven by a desire not just to excel in their careers but also to help others and have a positive impact. So as you think about your own post-MBA career goals, include a longer-term view about the areas where you think you can affect real change. Whether that means using technology to transform an industry, creating a niche business in the world of finance or medicine, or influencing the agenda for social attitudes in a region of the world, such a vision will carry far more weight if you can point to activities and commitments from your past and present that underpin your passion and sense of purpose. The school considers that past actions are usually the best predictor of future behavior, so your application should reflect who you are through what you have done.

Tip #2 - Yield and the importance of fit

The admissions yield at Stanford GSB is second only to Harvard, which underlines the fact that the school is the top choice for many applicants. A yield above 80% also suggests that the GSB admissions team is very good at identifying those applicants who have a strong fit with the culture and values of the school. Stanford is a relatively small program of around 400 students, and is seeking to build a very close knit, supportive community. Successful applicants not only have academic pedigree, stellar GMAT scores and personal and professional accomplishments to their name. They also have integrity, the ability to open up, be vulnerable, and grow in a supportive yet challenging environment. As such, the Admissions office works very hard to bring together a group of students who are open, humble and have strong integrity and this provides the foundation of the level of camaraderie and trust that you find at the school. Does that sound like you? Then share your story with the school in a natural, genuine way.

Tip #3 - Career goals

Pretty much all of the leading business schools can all open the door to McKinsey, Bain, BCG, Goldman and Morgan Stanley. Only 18% of the Stanford Class of 2013 went in to consulting, and 5 times as many secured a place in private equity or venture capital as investment banking. 16% of the class is starting a new business, many of them in the technology sector. The school likes you to dream big, while demonstrating that your goals and career vision are viable given your track record of achievement and excellence.



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Tip #4 - Contributing to life on 'The Farm'

For a program that consistently ranks among the top 2 or 3 in business school rankings, the Stanford MBA does not need to hear from you how wonderful it is. The brand and reputation of the school speak for themselves. But you do need to show your passion and absolute commitment to the school. The admissions team wants to understand how you can contribute to the Stanford community, and how the education you receive will provide the knowledge and skills to make the difference in your career. A campus visit, attending an info session and reaching out to students and alumni are all opportunities to better familiarize yourself with the distinct personality of the school.

So take the time to research the many clubs and organizations available at both the business school and the wider Stanford University campus, 'The Farm', and think about how you can bring energy and engagement outside the MBA classroom. There is no perfect candidate, so be honest about the areas in which you can improve, and how you hope to make the most of your two years in Palo Alto.

Tip #5 - What matters most to you?

This notorious essay is at the heart of the MBA application to the Stanford GSB, and typically ties applicants in knots as they try to come up with an answer that they hope is clever, striking, or even profound. The school is looking not just for extremely bright and successful individuals, but also people who have strong values and want to have a positive impact in the world. Taking the time to really think about this question provides invaluable insight about your life purpose and values, and the true you that emerges from this introspection helps the GSB to evaluate fit and diversity of contribution to the class.

To best tackle the structure of this essay, start with identifying a person, event, or experience that greatly impacted you, and think about the morals, values, and lessons you gained from this experience or interaction. How do you use these lessons today, and how do they impact your drive, your motivation, and your vision of the world? Can you link them to the development of your career and the life choices you have made? You also need to make the connection between your values and your career vision, and why these goals are important to you. Even though you might have to spend hours on this essay through brainstorming, research, talking with others, writing a draft, then another (and then another), just remember that it's all inside you... it's your story, and you just have to find it and pull it out.

Tip #6 - Importance of recommenders

We cannot emphasize enough how important recommendations are at the GSB. Stanford may have reduced the number of recommendations required from three to two, but the endorsement of a third-party who has genuine insight into your work, what makes you tick, and how you compare to your peers can carry more weight than anything you share in your essays. The school would like to hear from your current direct supervisor who needs to provide detailed examples that support the assertions they are making. All too often a recommendation sounds too generalized, and though positive and supportive it could have been written about many young professionals rather than specifically about you. This is particularly true for letters that come from partners in a consulting firm or directors at an investment bank, who may have been asked on numerous occasions to write a reference for business school. The temptation is for them to use a template they have on their hard drive, and though undeniably efficient for them this will do you more harm than good. The school is already swamped with applications from these industries, so you need to make sure that they take the time to produce something thoughtful, enthusiastic, and personalized to you.



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Tip #7 - Authenticity and humility

With 17 applications for each place in the MBA program at the Stanford Graduate School of Business, it is no surprise that candidates feel enormous pressure to stand out in the crowded applicant pool by producing impressive application essays and letters of recommendation for their admissions file.

But you can go too far in a bid to secure your place, and replace authenticity and self-confidence with boastfulness and arrogance. The Assistant Dean of MBA Admissions acknowledges that boastfulness can be an easy trap to fall into when candidates spend their time worrying how they compare to other applicants. But he states that personal humility is not inconsistent with professional ambition and professional drive. And humility is certainly one of the traits the GSB is looking for in its admits.

So while there are many approaches to creating a compelling application, there is clearly an appropriate tone to strike in your application. Rather than pumping up your accomplishments in the hope of impressing the admissions reader, or indulging in heavy self-promotion to blow away the competition, striking a humble tone with thoughtful illustration is the best way forward.

More about Fortuna Admissions:

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, MIT Sloan, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: [FortunaAdmissions.com](https://www.FortunaAdmissions.com)

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

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